What Is Anxiety? Understanding Your Body's Alarm System

A foundational guide from Real Psychiatric Services to help you understand anxiety and develop effective coping strategies.

by Mike Sullivan

A Personal Welcome

Meet Your Guide

I'm David Glenn, a psychiatric nurse practitioner. I've helped people with anxiety for years.

If you're here, anxiety is likely making your life harder than it needs to be.

What You Need to Know

You're not broken. Anxiety isn't your fault.

With the right understanding, it gets better.

Today, we'll explore what anxiety is and why your body creates it.

Think of Anxiety Like a Car Alarm

Helpful Alarms

A good car alarm goes off when someone's breaking in. That's helpful protection.

Oversensitive Alarms

What if your car alarm went off every time a leaf touched it? Exhausting and unhelpful.

Your Brain's Alarm

That's anxiety. Your brain has a powerful alarm system for real danger. Sometimes it becomes too sensitive.

How Anxiety Appears in Your Life

In Your Thoughts

"What if..." scenarios on repeat. Worst-case thinking. Difficulty concentrating. Mind going blank.

In Your Body

Racing heart. Shallow breathing. Sweating. Stomach in knots. Muscle tension.

In Your Actions

Avoiding places or people. Canceling plans. Checking things repeatedly. Fidgeting. Feeling frozen.

Is This Normal, or Is It a Problem?

Normal Anxiety

Everyone gets anxious sometimes. That's your alarm working correctly!

Job interviews, medical tests, first dates—your brain *should* be a little alert.

Problem Anxiety

Becomes a problem when it:

- Shows up when you're actually safe
- Feels way too intense for the situation
- Sticks around too long after events
- Makes you avoid things that matter

The good news? This is fixable with the right tools.

Let's Break Down Harmful Myths

Myth: "Just think positive"

Truth: Anxiety isn't just a thinking problem. It's a real, physical response. You can't just "think" your way out.

Myth: "You're being dramatic"

Truth: The physical and emotional feelings are very real. It's not an act; it's a biological process.

Myth: "You should be stronger"

Truth: Anxiety has nothing to do with strength. It affects people from all walks of life.

What's Next on Your Journey?

Body Check

Right now, do a quick body check. Are your shoulders tight? Jaw clenched? Are you holding your breath?

This is the first step: noticing how anxiety lives in your body.

Pay Attention

This week, your only job is to start paying attention. Not to judge yourself, but to become curious.

Identify Triggers

Next, we'll become "anxiety detectives" to figure out what triggers YOUR alarm. Knowledge is power.

You've Already Taken the Hardest Step

988	741741	911
Crisis Call/Text	Crisis Text Line	Emergency
In the U.S. and Canada	Text HOME to connect	For immediate help

You took a big step just by being here. That takes courage. Be proud of that.

Your anxiety can get better. Let's do this together.